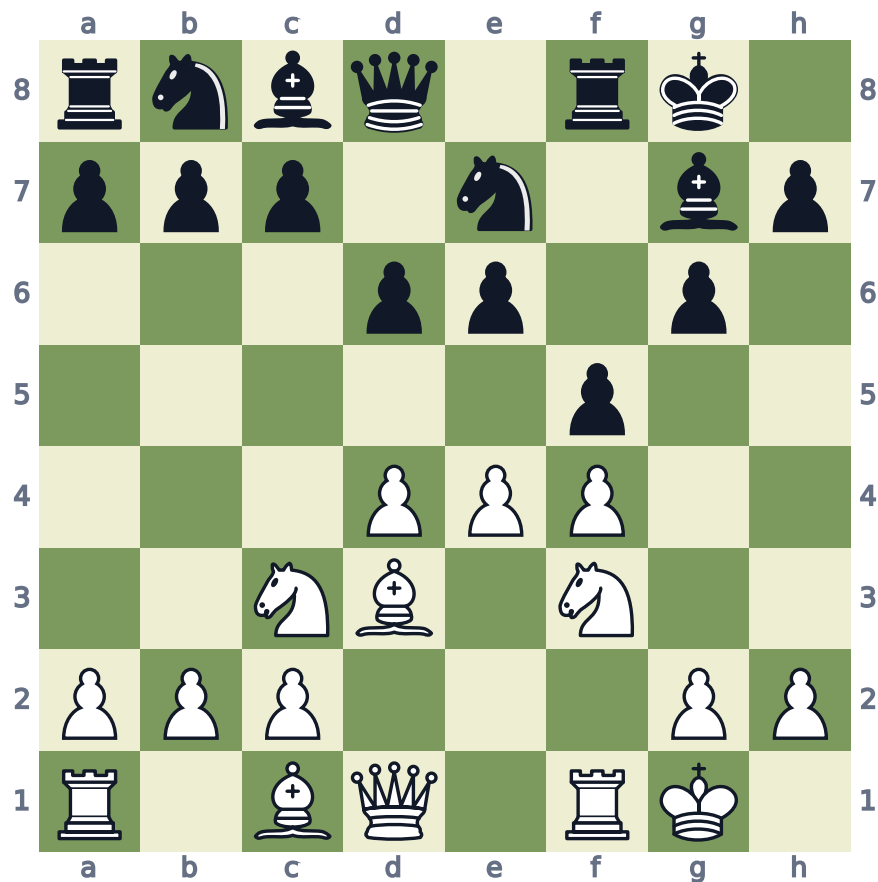


The Hippo f5 and b5 Breaks

Kingside counterstrikes, queenside expansion, pawn races, and restraint



Launch the Hippo's wing breaks with calculation, recognize when they complement a central break, and avoid attacking on the wrong side.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Launch the Hippo's wing breaks with calculation, recognize when they complement a central break, and avoid attacking on the wrong side.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

f5 challenges e4 and can open the f-file, but it also weakens the king.

PRINCIPLE 2

b5 gains queenside space and supports b4, especially against long castling.

PRINCIPLE 3

A wing break is strongest when the center is stable or opens in your favor.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Opposite-side attacks are races measured in forcing moves, not intentions.

PRINCIPLE 5

The rook and queen must have useful files after the pawn moves.

PRINCIPLE 6

Sometimes the best wing-break lesson is to postpone it and meet a central threat.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

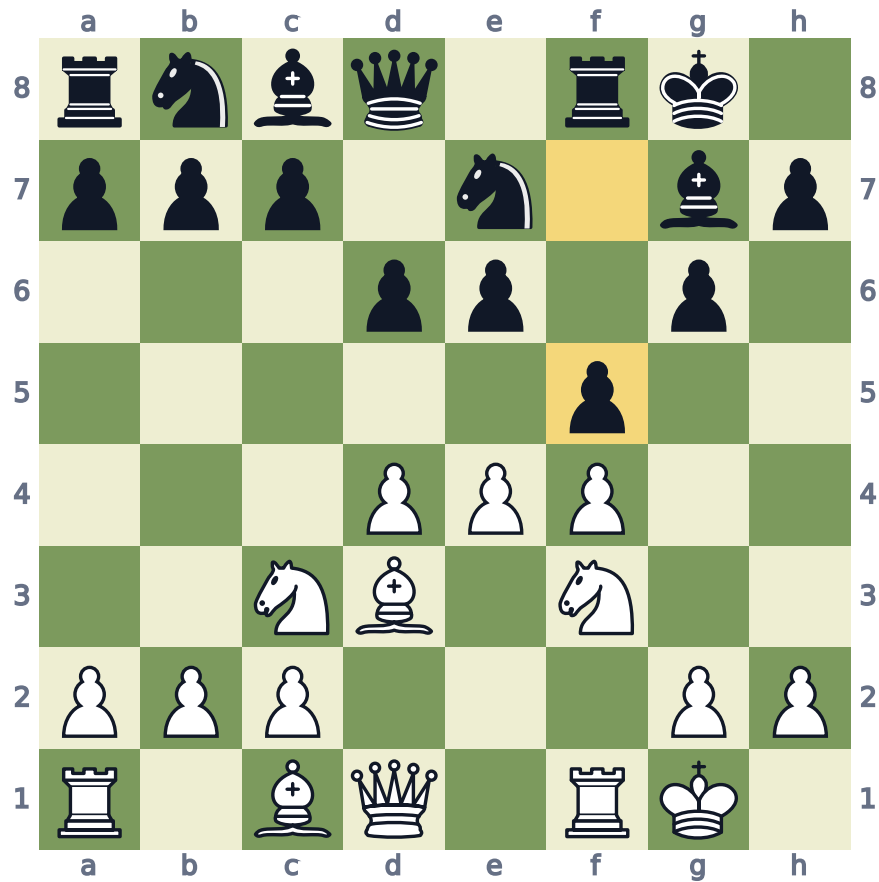
- | | | |
|-----------|---|---|
| 01 | f5 against the Austrian center | The f-pawn is a lever, not a shield; calculate the opened file. |
| 02 | f5 against long-castle preparation | White's king location can make f5 safer but does not remove central tactics. |
| 03 | f5 against a four-pawn center | Attack the chain before it moves; afterwards the target may disappear. |
| 04 | f5 in the reversed Austrian | A reversed opening requires faster calculation, not copied moves. |
| 05 | b5 with central stability | Prepare b5 with a6 and piece support; then ask what opens after the exchange. |
| 06 | b5 against the Botvinnik English | Against c4, b5 is a direct lever only if the center is not about to open. |
| 07 | b5 in a Reti transposition | A wing break must survive the opponent's best central reply. |
| 08 | When b5 should be restrained | A prevented break is information; switch plans instead of forcing it. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

f5 against the Austrian center



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 O-O 7. O-O f5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack e4 and contest the kingside before White plays f5.

MAIN DANGER

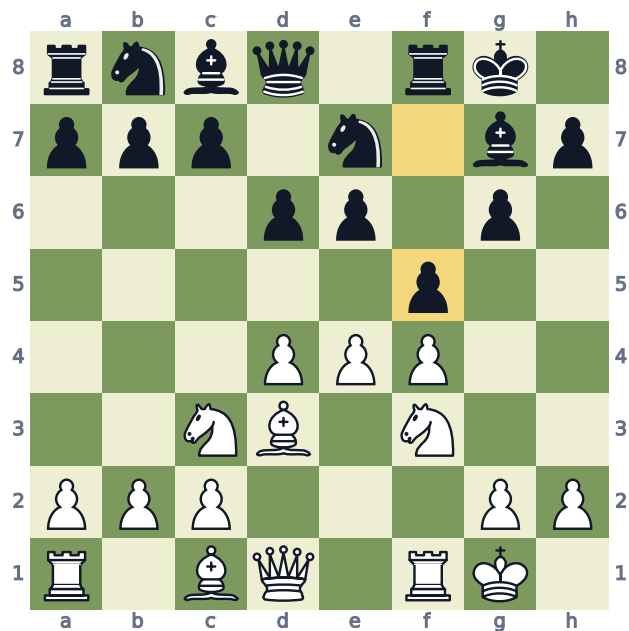
exf5 can expose Black's king and the e6 pawn.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The f-pawn is a lever, not a shield; calculate the opened file.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

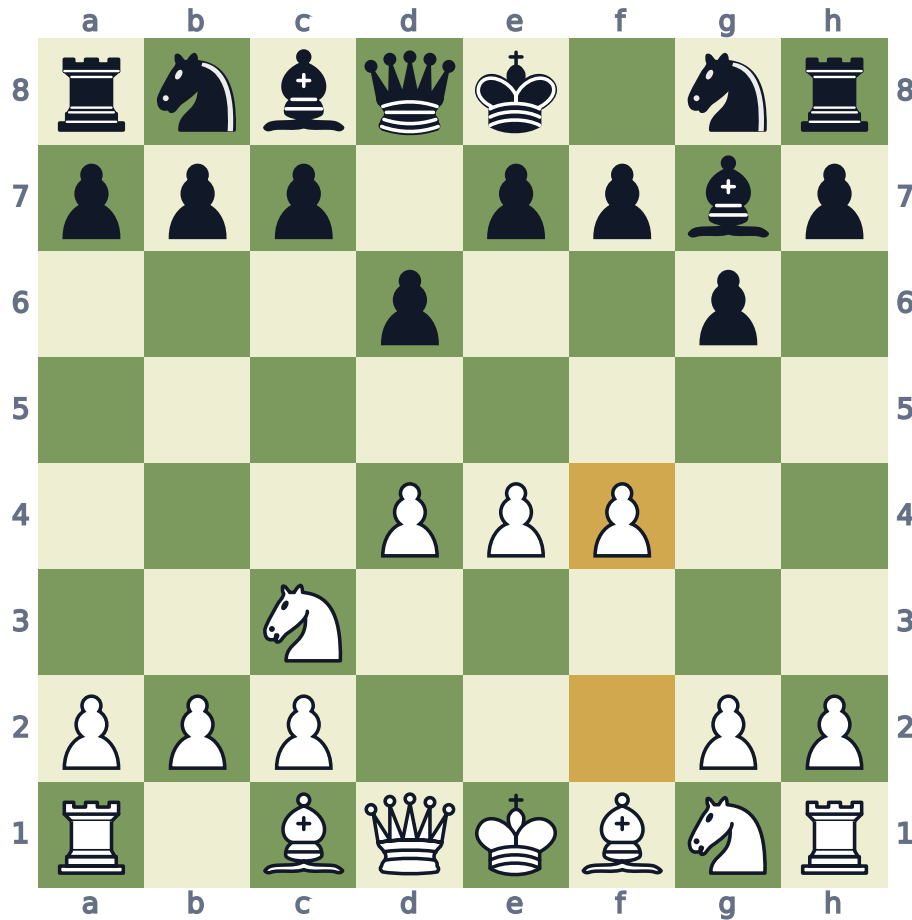
Position estimate: +0.95 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. e5 a6 2. a4 Nbc6 3. Be3 Nb4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

f5 against the Austrian center



YOUR TASK

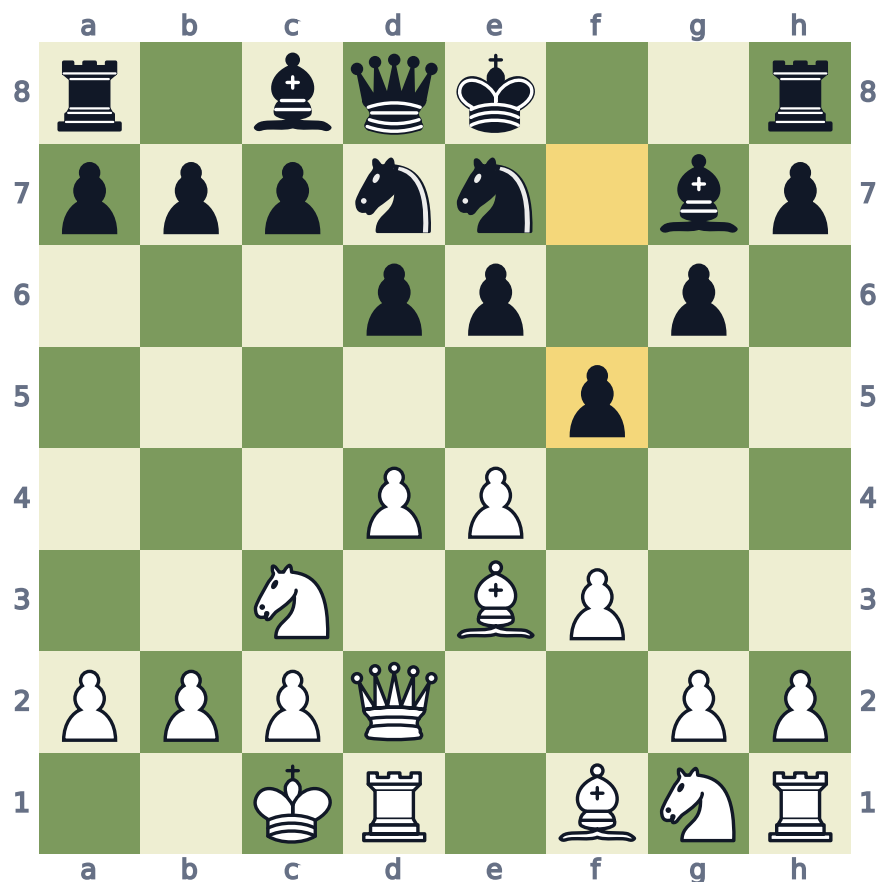
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

f5 against long-castle preparation



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 f5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge e4 while White's king is headed away from the f-file.

MAIN DANGER

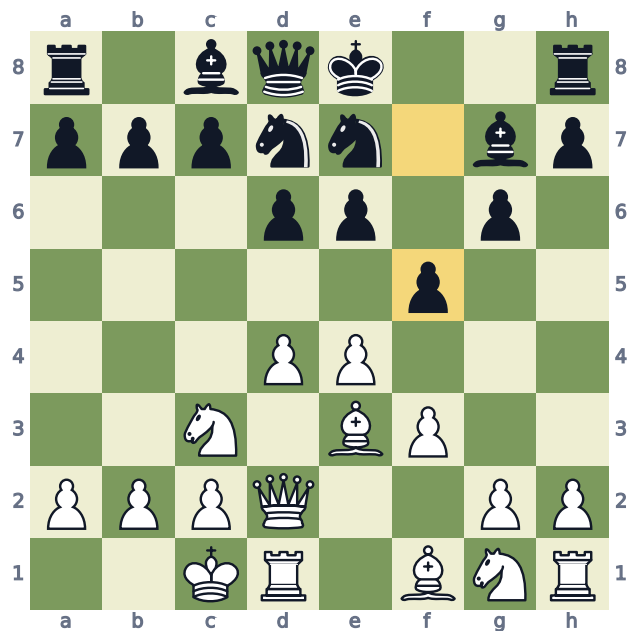
h4-h5 may arrive before Black creates queenside counterplay.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

White's king location can make f5 safer but does not remove central tactics.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +2.01 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h4 Nf6 2. Bd3 a6 3. Nh3 b5 4. e5 Nfd5 5. Nxd5 Nxd5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

f5 against long-castle preparation



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

f5 against a four-pawn center



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. f4 Ne7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2 f5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Break the e4-f4 chain before White advances both pawns.

MAIN DANGER

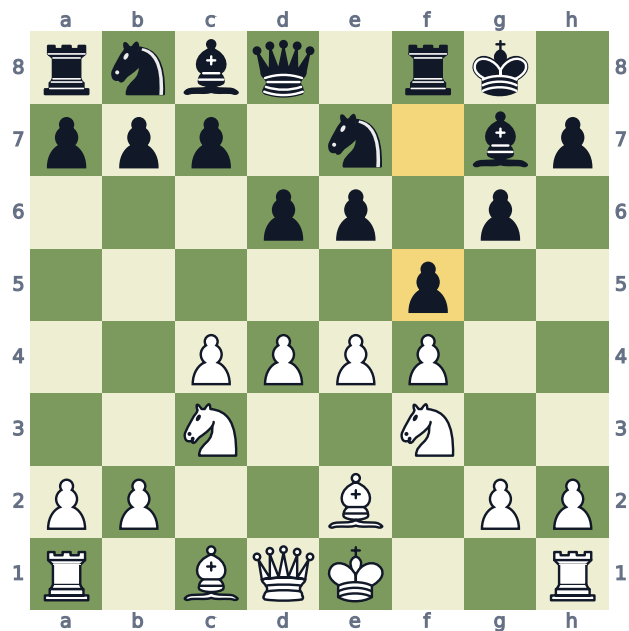
e5 can close the position and gain kingside space.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Attack the chain before it moves; afterwards the target may disappear.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.06 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. e5 dxe5 2. fxe5 c5 3. d5 Nd7 4. Bf4 Nb6 5. d6 Nc6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

f5 against a four-pawn center



YOUR TASK

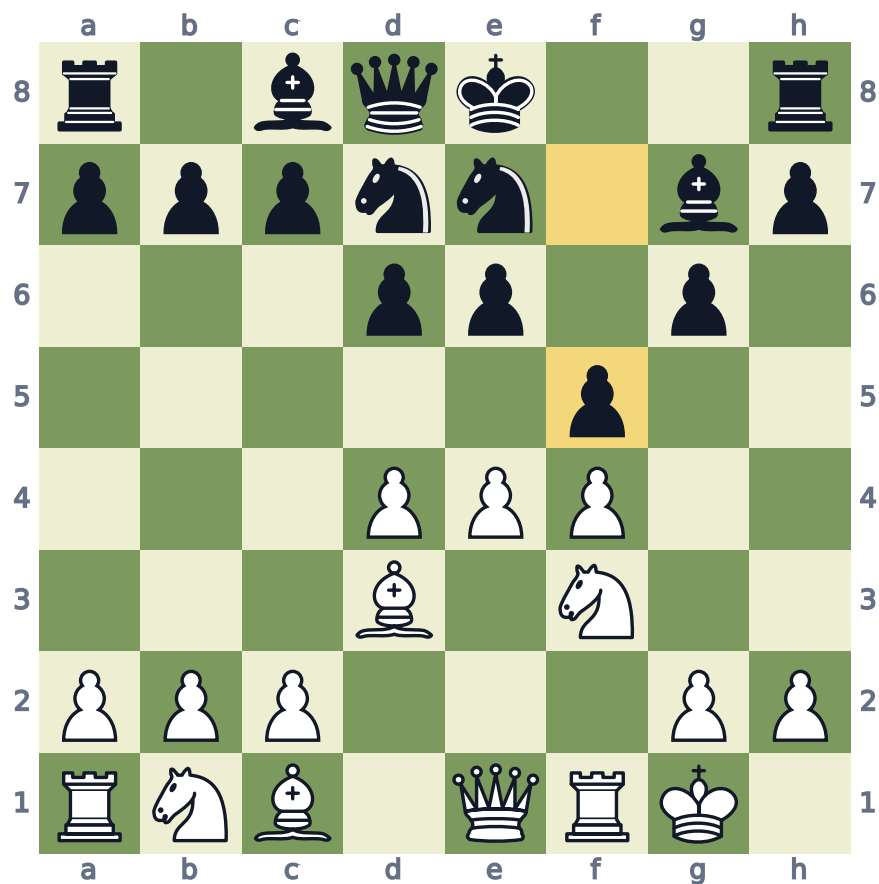
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

f5 in the reversed Austrian



COURSE LINE

1. f4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e4 d6 4. d4 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Qe1 f5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use symmetrical contact to exploit White's exposed e4 pawn.

MAIN DANGER

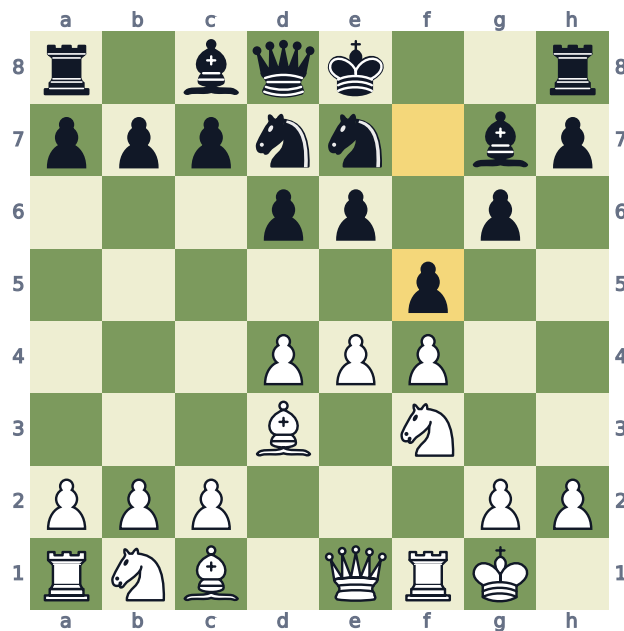
e5 can gain time and space because White has an extra tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A reversed opening requires faster calculation, not copied moves.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.41 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nc3 O-O 2. e5 dxe5 3. fxe5 c5 4. Ng5 Nb6 5. dxc5 Nbd5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

f5 in the reversed Austrian



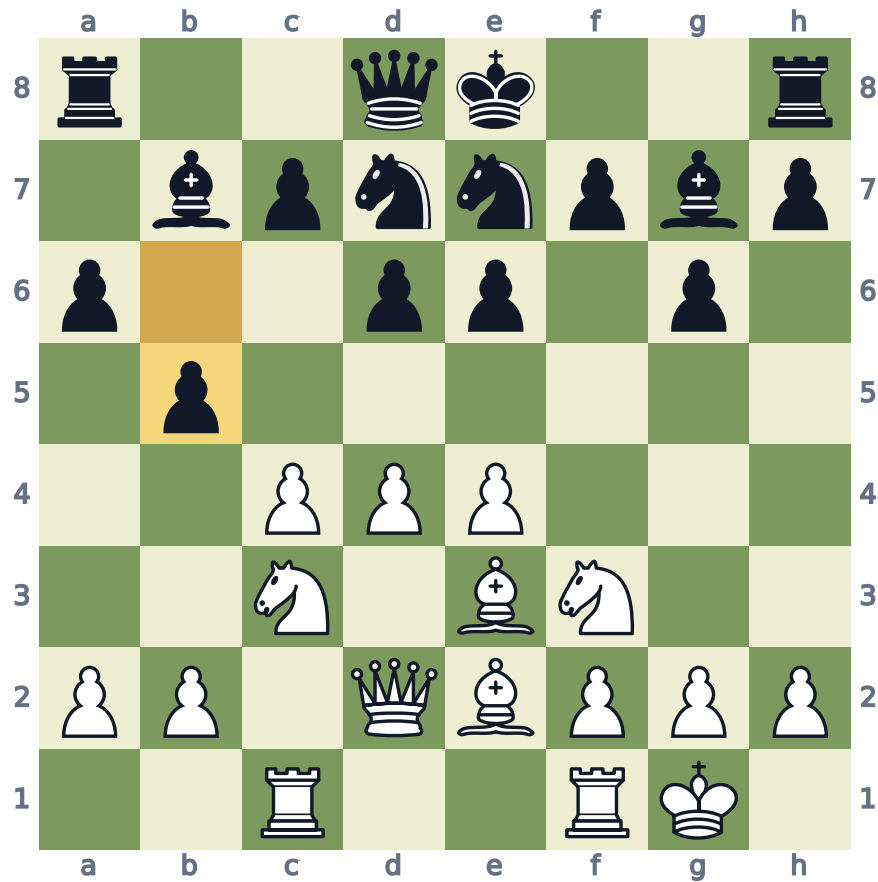
YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

b5 with central stability**COURSE LINE**

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O b6 8. Be3 Bb7 9. Qd2 a6 10. Rac1 b5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Gain queenside space and threaten b4 while the center remains closed enough.

MAIN DANGER

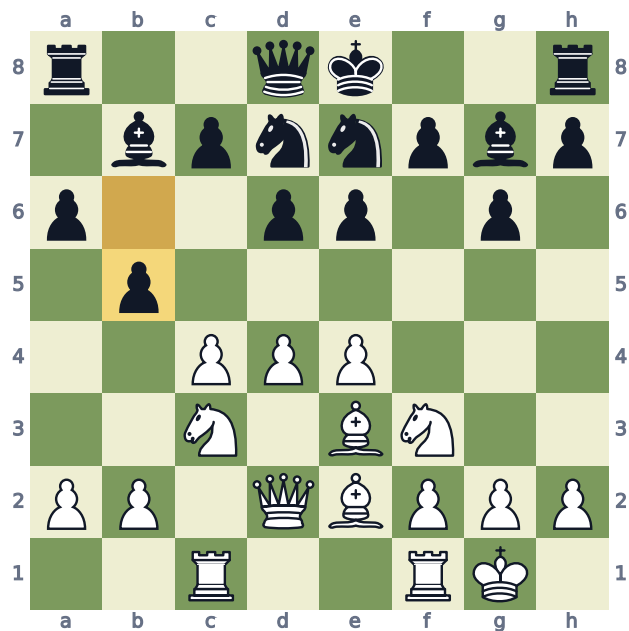
cxb5 or a central e5 break can make the wing pawns weak.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 10 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Prepare b5 with a6 and piece support; then ask what opens after the exchange.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.80 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. cxb5 axb5 2. Bxb5 c6 3. Bd3 O-O 4. a4 c5 5. Rfd1

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

b5 with central stability**YOUR TASK**

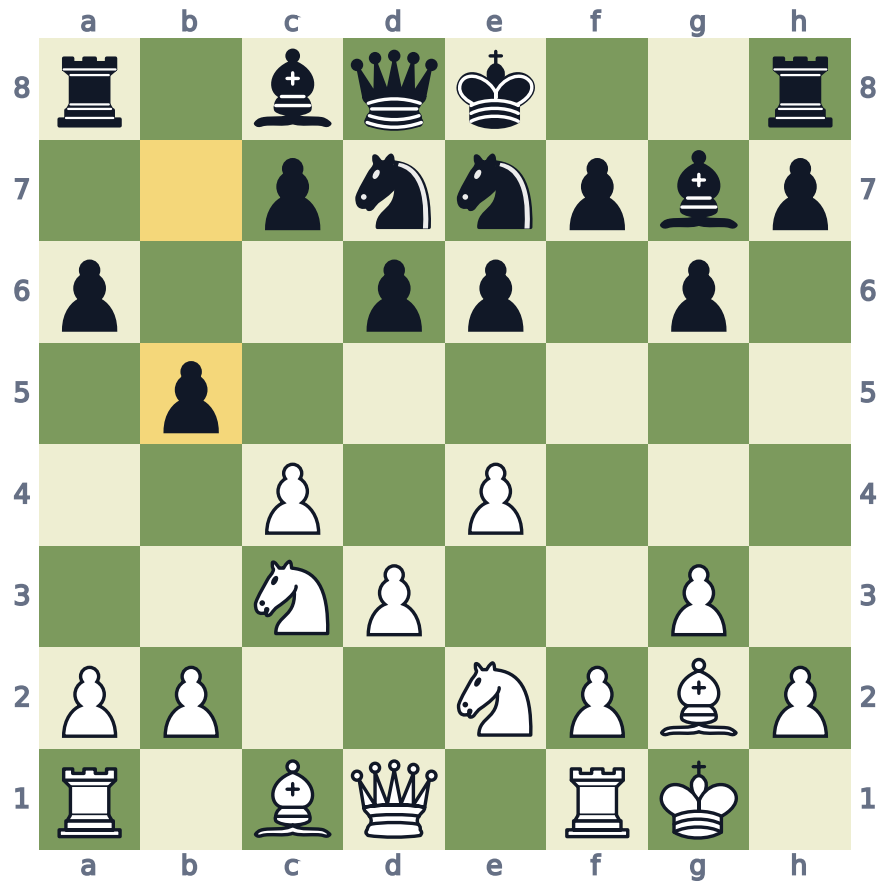
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

b5 against the Botvinnik English



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 Nd7 7. Nge2 a6 8. O-O b5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

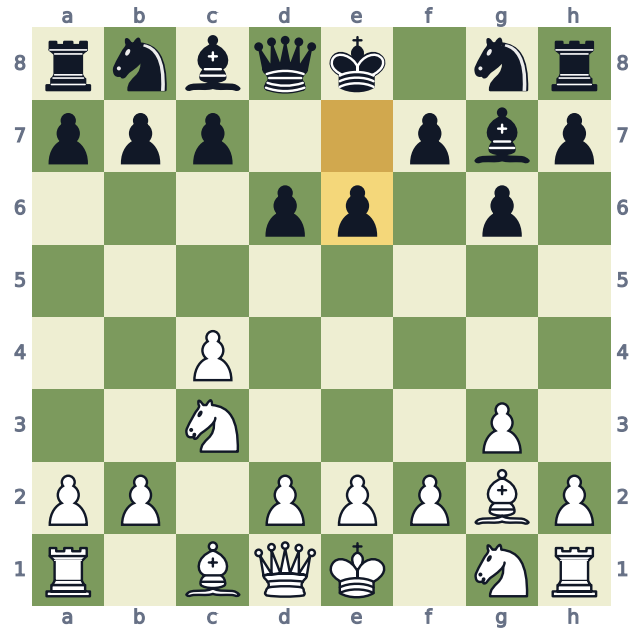
Create queenside space and pressure c4 before White's f4 attack.

MAIN DANGER

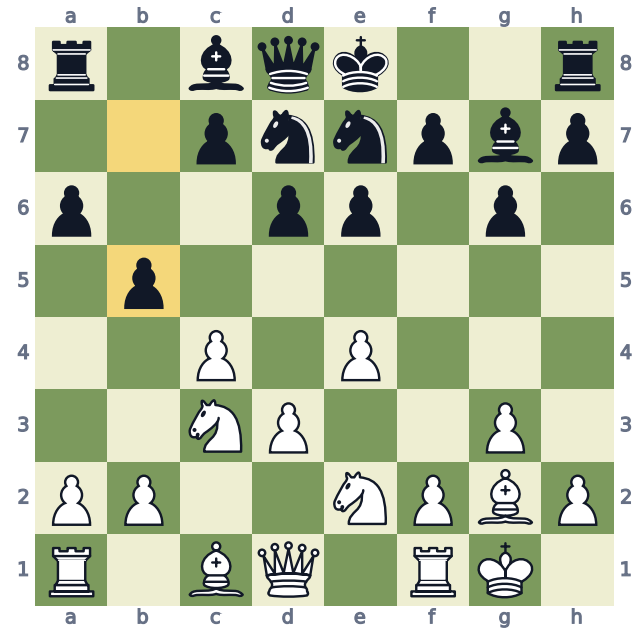
cxb5 can open the a-file or leave a weak b-pawn.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against c4, b5 is a direct lever only if the center is not about to open.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

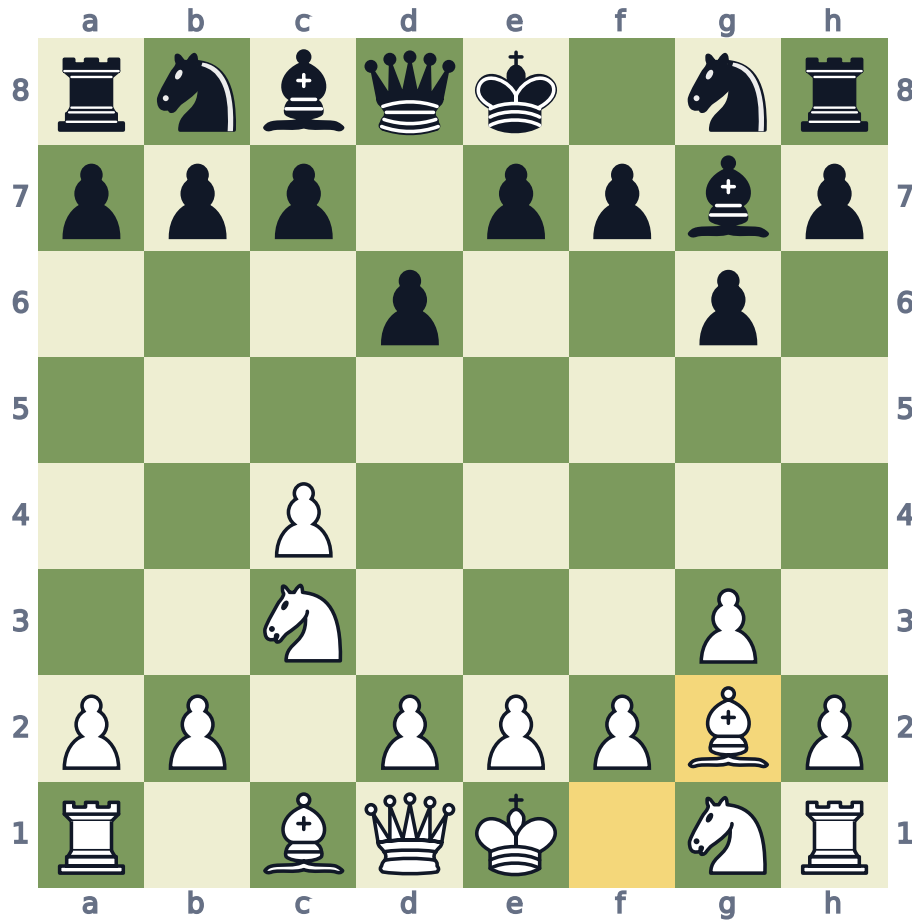
Position estimate: +0.27 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Rb1 O-O 2. cxb5 axb5 3. Nxb5 Ba6 4. a4 Qb8 5. Qc2 c6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

b5 against the Botvinnik English



YOUR TASK

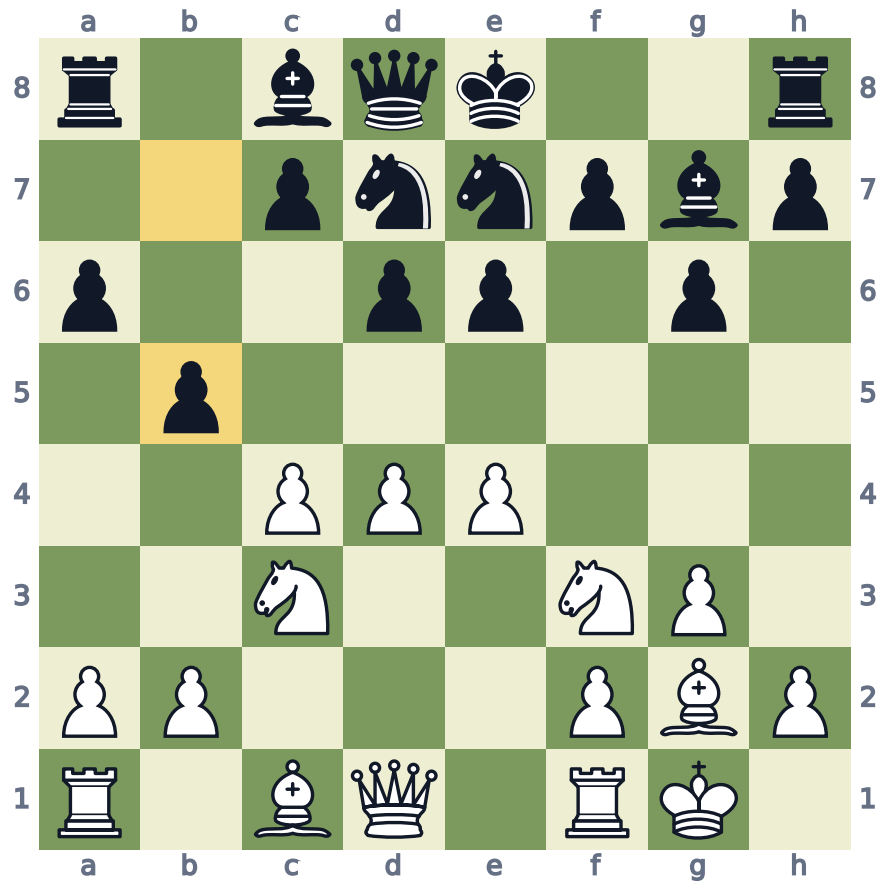
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

b5 in a Reti transposition



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. c4 Nd7 7. Nc3 a6 8. e4 b5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

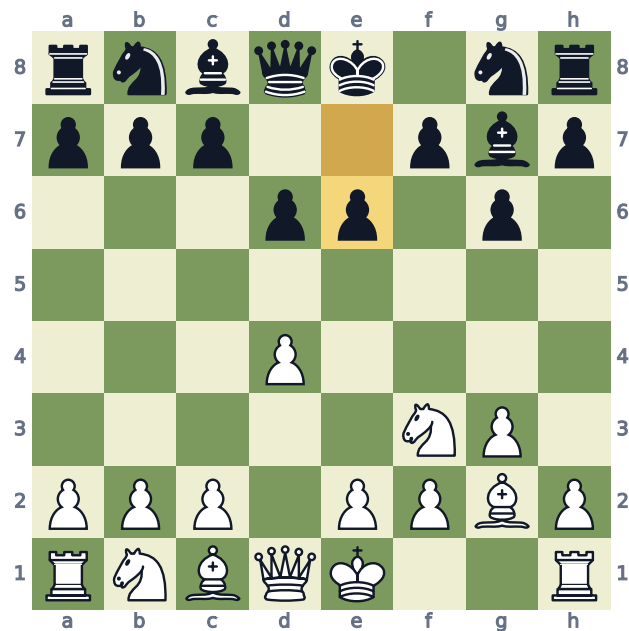
Gain space and make b4 a threat against the c3 knight.

MAIN DANGER

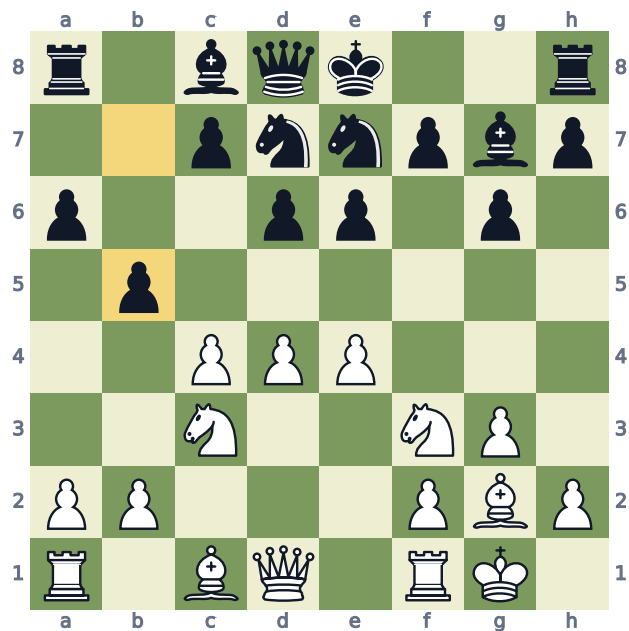
e5 can punish a wing move if Black's center is underprepared.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A wing break must survive the opponent's best central reply.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

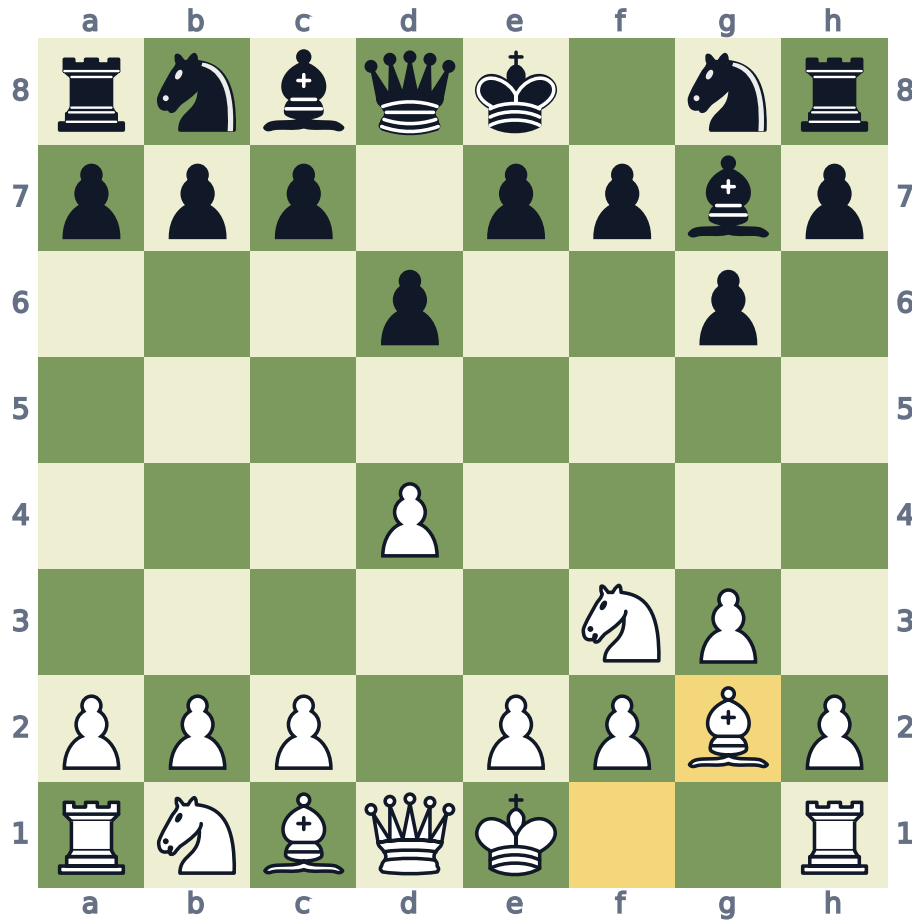
Position estimate: +0.71 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. d5 bxc4 2. dxe6 fxe6 3. Qa4 O-O 4. Qxc4 Nb6 5. Qb3 Rb8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

b5 in a Reti transposition



YOUR TASK

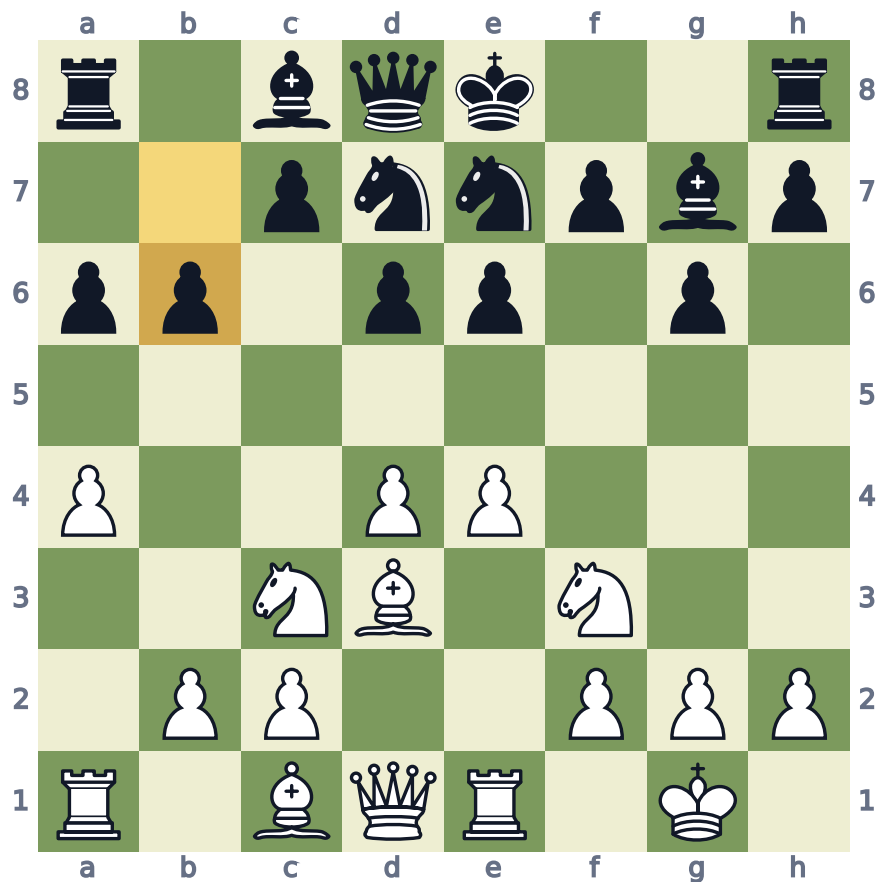
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

When b5 should be restrained



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 a6 8. a4 b6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use b6 and Bb7 instead of forcing b5 into White's a4 restraint.

MAIN DANGER

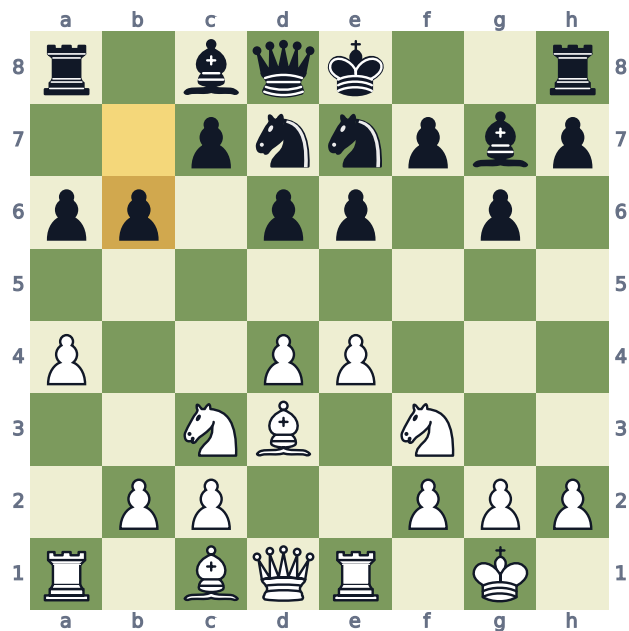
White may use a5 to fix queenside weaknesses.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A prevented break is information; switch plans instead of forcing it.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.86 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Ne2 c5 2. c3 O-O 3. h4 h6 4. Bf4 e5 5. Be3 exd4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

When b5 should be restrained



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. F5 AGAINST THE AUSTRIAN CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Attack e4 and contest the kingside before White plays f5. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nf3 2. O-O Bd3 3. c5 dxc5 4. dxc5 h3 (+0.69 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: exf5 can expose Black's king and the e6 pawn.

02. F5 AGAINST LONG-CASTLE PREPARATION

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge e4 while White's king is headed away from the f-file. Engine comparison: 1. Nd7 Nf3 2. a6 a4 3. c5 dxc5 4. Nxc5 Bxc5 5. Bxc3+ bxc3 (+0.73 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: h4-h5 may arrive before Black creates queenside counterplay.

03. F5 AGAINST A FOUR-PAWN CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Break the e4-f4 chain before White advances both pawns. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: e5 can close the position and gain kingside space.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. F5 IN THE REVERSED AUSTRIAN

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use symmetrical contact to exploit White's exposed e4 pawn. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nc3 2. c5 Bb5+ 3. Bd7 Bxd7+ 4. Nbx d7 d5 5. O-O a4 (+0.61 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: e5 can gain time and space because White has an extra tempo.

05. B5 WITH CENTRAL STABILITY

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Gain queenside space and threaten b4 while the center remains closed enough. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. b6 e5 4. dxe5 Nxe5 5. Nfd7 Bf3 (+0.88 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: cxb5 or a central e5 break can make the wing pawns weak.

06. B5 AGAINST THE BOTVINNIK ENGLISH

Course move: e6. Purpose: Create queenside space and pressure c4 before White's f4 attack. Engine comparison: 1. Nc6 Rb1 2. a5 d3 3. Nf6 h3 4. O-O a3 5. e6 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: cxb5 can open the a-file or leave a weak b-pawn.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. B5 IN A RETI TRANSPOSITION

Course move: e6. Purpose: Gain space and make b4 a threat against the c3 knight. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 c4 2. Nbd7 Nc3 3. O-O O-O 4. e5 Qc2 5. Re8 Be3 (+0.50 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: e5 can punish a wing move if Black's center is underprepared.

08. WHEN B5 SHOULD BE RESTRAINED

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use b6 and Bb7 instead of forcing b5 into White's a4 restraint. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: White may use a5 to fix queenside weaknesses.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.